Eduqas GCSE Geography B (C112QS) — Component 2: Problem Solving Geography

4.1 Problem Solving Geography

1. What Is Component 2?

Component 2 is a **1 hour 30 minute** written exam worth **30% of the GCSE**. It is a decision-making paper: you are given a **Resource Folder** in the exam (there is **no pre-release**) about an unfamiliar geographical issue, and you work through it step by step until you choose and justify a solution.

The issue can come from **any of the three themes** you studied for Component 1, and questions deliberately link them together. The June 2024 paper, for example, was about **desertification in Bahrain**, but also tested climate graphs, development indicators (Theme 1), the water cycle, over-abstraction and climate change (Themes 2 and 3).

Part	What it asks you to do	Suggested time	June 2024 marks
Part A	Consider the issue — where it happens, why, and the problems it causes	About 40 minutes	36
Part B	Explore possible solutions, usually from different places around the world	About 25 minutes	24
Part C	Decide which solution is best for the place in the question and justify your choice	About 25 minutes	12 + 4 SPaG

Exam Tip — use the advised timings: Part C carries 16 marks but comes last. Students who spend too long on Part A run out of time for the decision. Keep to roughly 40 / 25 / 25 minutes.

2. Using the Resource Folder

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The folder contains maps, graphs, tables, photographs, diagrams and short articles. You will be told which figure to use for each question.

1. **Skim the whole folder first** (2–3 minutes) so you know what evidence exists — you will need it again in Part C.
2. For each figure, check the **title, key, units, scale and dates** before answering.
3. **Quote evidence**: figures, place names and dates. "Use data" questions are capped if you don't.
4. Watch for the **source and date** of articles — an advert or campaign group may be biased.
5. Don't copy long chunks of text from the folder — mark schemes warn examiners about direct copying, and you gain marks by *explaining* or *evaluating* the information.

3. Part A — Understanding the Issue

Part A has many short, skills-based questions followed by a few longer explanations. Expect:

Question type	Example (June 2024)	How to answer
Describe a global pattern from a map	Describe the global pattern of vulnerability to desertification [3]	General pattern first ("found on every continent except…"), then concentrations with named areas, then exceptions. Not a list of places.
Describe a location	Describe the location of Bahrain [2]	Continent/region, latitude lines, direction from named countries or seas. Write "south-western Asia", not "south-west of Asia" (which means outside Asia).
Recall definitions and characteristics	Give two characteristics of a NIC [2]; circle three features of a hot, semi-arid climate [3]	Short, precise statements. Extra circles or ticks lose marks.
Complete a diagram	Label precipitation, interception, evapotranspiration and infiltration on a tree diagram [4]	Know the water cycle and other key diagrams from Component 1.

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Calculations	Median of −21, −16, −16, +200 [2]; why is the median more appropriate than the mean? [1]	Show working; keep negative signs and units. An outlier skews the mean.
Explain (4–6 marks)	Explain why over-abstraction of water causes problems [6]	Chains of reasoning: cause → effect → further consequence, for people and the environment.

Development data — limitations

Problem-solving papers often include a table of development indicators (GNI per capita, literacy, life expectancy, % of GNI from farming). Be ready to explain the limits of using data to measure development:

- A single indicator shows only one aspect of a complex idea.
- National averages hide inequality between regions, rich and poor, or men and women.
- Data can be inaccurate, out of date or manipulated by governments.
- Some aspects of quality of life, such as happiness or freedom, are hard to measure.

4. Part B — Evaluating Possible Solutions

Part B introduces solutions, often each tried in a different country. In 2024 there were three for desertification:

Solution	Example in the folder	Advantages	Disadvantages
Advanced technology (satellites, drones, soil-moisture sensors, genetic engineering)	California, USA	Water used precisely, so less is wasted and over-abstraction is avoided; crops survive and soil stays covered	Expensive; needs training, infrastructure and maintenance; some research takes decades (tree crops need 20+ years to mature)
Sand dams	Zimbabwe	Cheap local materials; low-tech and community-maintained; stored water is	Need seasonal sandy rivers; pumps must be manufactured,

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		protected from evaporation; solar pump uses no fossil fuel	transported and repaired; may reduce flow downstream
Drought-tolerant crops	Guatemala	Survive dry years, so soil is protected and families have food and income; less irrigation needed	May give lower yields or prices; seeds must be obtained; do not tackle wider causes such as over-abstraction

Sustainability means meeting the needs of people today without preventing future generations from meeting theirs. Evaluate solutions against all three strands:
Social — health, food security, education, communities staying together.
Economic — cost to build and maintain, jobs, incomes, debt.
Environmental — soils, water, biodiversity, pollution, carbon emissions.

"Evaluate how ... could be considered sustainable" (6 marks)

The mark scheme caps answers with no evaluation at 5 marks. To reach the top band:

- Explain how the solution is sustainable in at least two strands, with chains of reasoning.
- Consider the **short and long term**.
- Include at least one way it could be **unsustainable**, then weigh up.

Model paragraph — sand dams: Sand dams are environmentally sustainable because water stored in the sand is protected from evaporation, so farmers have water in the dry season without pumping groundwater, and crops protect the soil from erosion. They are economically sustainable because walls are built from cheap local materials and maintained by the community without specialist training. *However*, the solar pump must be manufactured and transported, and if it breaks and nobody can repair it, the system stops working; trapping water could also reduce the river's flow for communities downstream. Overall they are highly sustainable where there are seasonal sandy rivers, provided local people are trained to maintain the pumps.

Attitudes and viewpoints

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Expect a question on why people hold different views — for example why attitudes to climate change vary: the problem feels global so individual action seems pointless; some people are not yet affected; change is inconvenient or expensive; natural climate change in the past leads some to doubt human causes; influential people or media deny it; people struggling now find it hard to prioritise the future. Give two reasons and develop each.

5. Part C — Making and Justifying a Decision

Part C asks you to choose **one** option for the place in the question and justify it, considering social, economic and environmental sustainability. It is marked in four bands out of 12, with 4 more marks for SPaG.

Band	What examiners look for
10–12	A substantiated decision with clear justification **for the chosen option over the others**; chains of reasoning covering social, economic and environmental effects; consistently detailed, using a range of evidence from the paper and Resource Folder
7–9	A justified decision; some chains of reasoning on sustainability; detailed elaboration supported by evidence
4–6	A decision simply justified; limited observations on sustainability; some evidence
1–3	A simple, unsubstantiated decision that briefly refers to effects

A structure that works

1. **Decision** — name your option in the first sentence.
2. **Why it suits this place** — link to the place's own data: wealth, physical geography, the main cause of the problem. In 2024, Bahrain's GNI per capita of $40,730 made technology affordable, while its lack of rivers made sand dams unsuitable.
3. **Sustainability** — a developed paragraph each on social, economic and environmental effects.
4. **Drawbacks** — admit a weakness of your option and say how it could be reduced.
5. **Why not the others** — a sentence or two on each rejected option, using evidence.

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6. **Conclusion** — restate the decision; you may suggest combining it with another option, but you must still make a clear choice.

Exam Tip — there is no right answer: Any option can reach full marks if it is well justified. Choose the option you can argue best with evidence from the folder, not the one you think the examiner wants. What separates the top band is explaining why your choice is better *for this particular place* than the alternatives.

Opening of a top-band answer (2024): "Bahrain should choose advanced technology. Unlike Zimbabwe or Guatemala, Bahrain is a wealthy NIC with a GNI per capita of $40,730, so it can afford drones and soil-moisture sensors. Its main cause of desertification is over-abstraction of groundwater on a small, hot island where temperatures have risen from about 26.5 °C to 29 °C since 1901, and precise irrigation would cut water use, protecting its aquifers from salt-water intrusion…"

6. Skills Checklist

Component 2 tests geographical skills heavily. Make sure you can:

- Describe patterns on world maps, choropleths and isoline maps, using compass directions and lines of latitude.
- Read and complete line graphs, bar charts, climate graphs and dual-axis graphs (e.g. population and water use).
- Extend a line on a graph to a forecast value.
- Calculate mean, median, mode, range, percentage change and ratios — and say which average suits the data.
- Interpret photographs and annotated diagrams.
- Spot bias and limitations in data and sources.
- Define key terms precisely — NIC, LIC, HIC, sustainability, over-abstraction, desertification, interception, infiltration.

7. Linking to Your Component 1 Themes

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Possible issue	Component 1 knowledge you would use
Desertification, drought, water supply	3.3 Water Resources, 3.4 Desertification, 2.3 Weather and Climate, 2.4 Climate Change
Coastal erosion, flooding, sea-level rise	2.1 Coasts, 2.2 Rivers, 2.4 Climate Change
Deforestation, conservation, tourism in fragile environments	3.1 How Ecosystems Function, 3.2 Ecosystems Under Threat
Urban growth, regeneration, development projects	1.1 Urbanisation, 1.2 Urban and Rural Change in the UK, 1.3 Development Issues
Energy, aid, trade, MNC investment	1.3 Development Issues, 2.4 Climate Change

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